or impossible for any other reason. He will also decide on the further travel arrangements for the Afghan Ambassador Hussein Ali.'[33] 'We need not remind you', wrote Count Nesselrode, at the end of his instructions, 'that all the aforesaid must be kept strictly confidential and nobody but our envoy to Persia, Count Simonitch, and Baron von Rosen should know of these instructions. Caution also requires that you leave all instructions with Count Simonitch when you set off to Afghanistan so that, should some misfortune befall you, nothing could reveal the secret of your mission.' It was of particular importance, warned Nesselrode, that the British discover nothing of these plans, and there was an implicit warning that he could be disowned by St Petersburg if the British did so.

Vitkevitch's notes for his journey south were burned just before his mysterious death, but Captain Blaramberg's memoirs survive. 'Having spent two months in St Petersburg and received my instructions,' he wrote, 'I was preparing to leave the city, but first I met my travelling companion Lieutenant Vitkevich. He turned out to be a pleasant young Pole, 28 years old, with an expressive face, well-educated and energetic . . . all the necessary qualities to play in Asia the role of Alexander Burnes.'[34]

The two travelled south in a carriage laden with presents and bribes for Persian and Afghan officials, and on arrival in Tiflis they met Baron von Rosen, the Commander-in-Chief, and visited Countess Simonitch, who 'became a frequent guest; her charming daughters bore a great resemblance to their astonishing mother'.

The further south they went from Tiflis, the more idyllic the countryside became. The two travellers slept out under the stars, and spent nights in the camps of nomads. 'On 11 July we crossed the border of the Yerivan province and the oppressive heat forced us to halt at a ruined mosque,' wrote Blaramberg.

> It was here that we saw the magnificent Mount Ararat for the first time: its double peak covered in glittering snow rose in the south over the plain. On the 13th we went over the last mountain ridge and descended into the Araxes valley. It was a beautiful day, not a cloud in the sky. We settled in the shade of a small grove by a babbling stream and admired the magnificent Ararat towering before us. Our Armenian manservant made a delicious pilaf and we, being in high spirits, emptied a bottle of Madeira.[35]

It was once they had crossed the Persian border that Vitkevitch's volatile temperament darkened. 'During our journey through Persia, Vitkevitch was